



Specific Cognitive Abilities Predict Socio-Political Attitudes Above and Beyond g



Ryan Dobson¹ & Tobias Edwards²

¹University of New Mexico, ²Univeresity of Minnesota

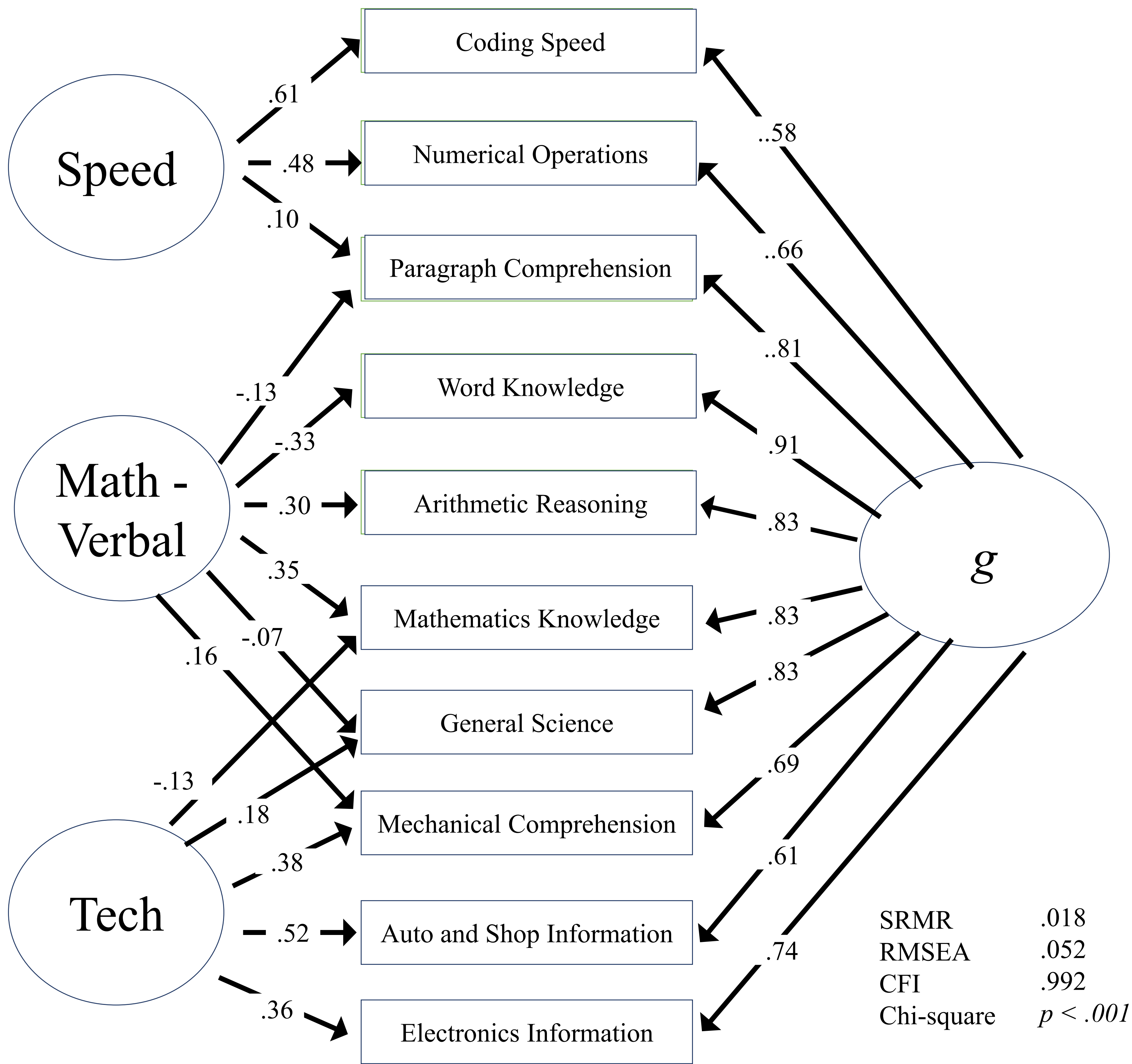
Background

- Recent research suggests that specific cognitive abilities predict socio-political attitudes above and beyond g (Edwards et al., 2025; Ludeke et al., 2017)
- Prior research is limited by its reliance on multiple regression, which cannot isolate latent specific abilities from g
- We use a latent trait structural equation modeling (SEM) approach to provide a more rigorous test of the important of non-g factors in predicting socio-political attitudes

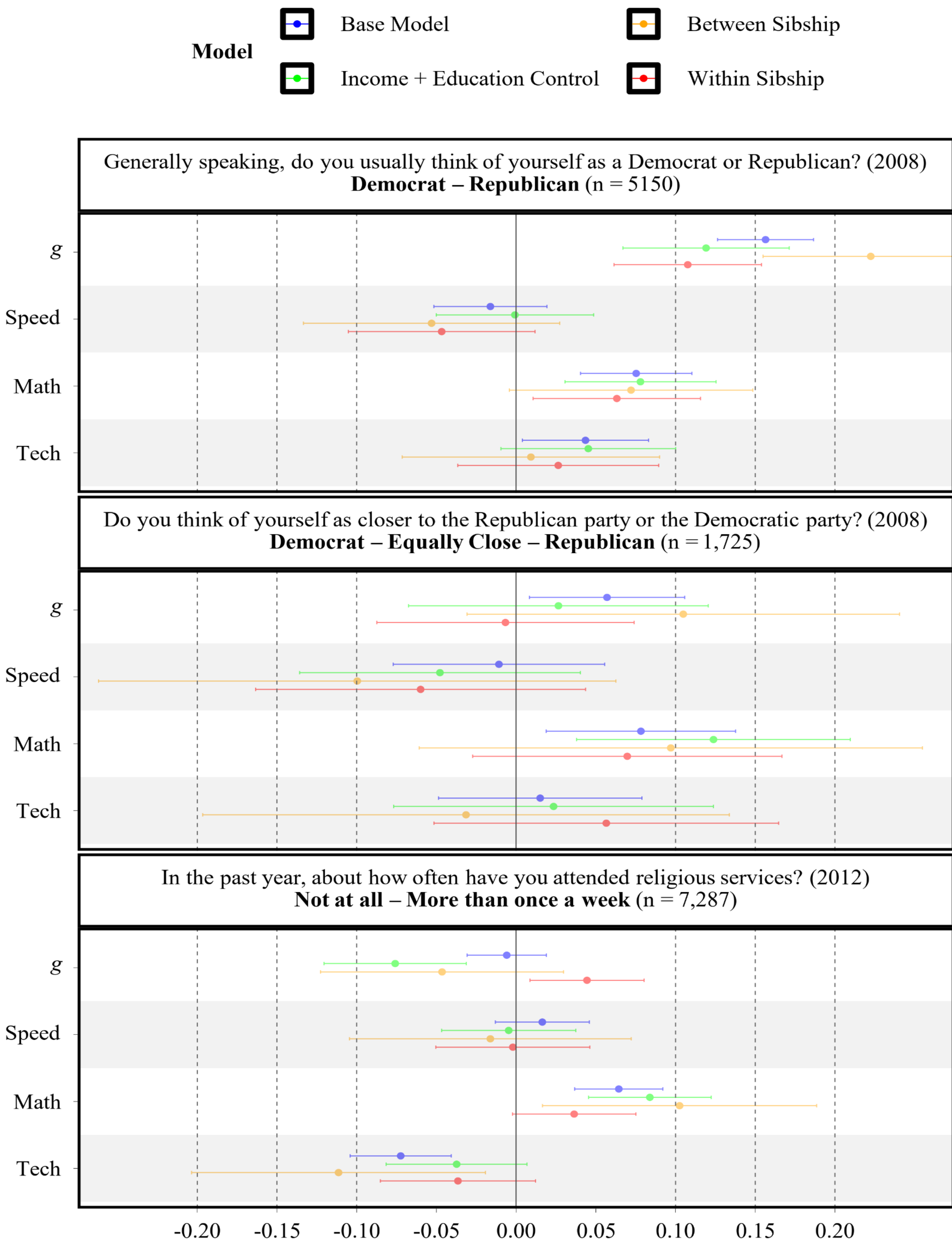
National Longitudinal Survey of Youth, 1979

- Representative cohort of men and women born in the U.S. between 1957 and 1964 who were 14 to 22 years-old when first interviewed in 1979
- 12,686 individuals in the full sample
- 2,031 families of full siblings identified with *NlsyLinks* R package
- The Armed Services Vocational Aptitude Battery (ASVAB) is a 10-domain aptitude test measuring cognitive abilities and was completed by 94% of the full sample in 1980

Bi-Factor CFA Model of ASVAB



SEMs of socio-political attitudes regressed on latent cognitive abilities reveal that the combined effects of specific abilities are comparable to or greater than g, underscoring their importance when considering the cognitive underpinnings of socio-political attitudes



Model	Outcome Variable		
	Party Identification	Party Closeness	Religious Attendance
Base Model	0.57	1.41	16.8
Income/Education	0.76	5.07	1.21
Between Sib-ship	0.40	1.36	3.28
Within Sib-ship	0.77	16.1	1.16